
We've Heard a Lot About RFK Jr.'s Affair With Olivia Nuzzi. There's One Big Thing the Conversation Is Missing.

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The one person involved—and, seemingly, the one person with a microphone—who has not weighed in on this mess of sex, lies, and journalistic malpractice is the secretary of health and human services, the harvest provider himself. Kennedy has weathered this period of sustained interest in his sex life by simply refusing to engage at all. He has declined or ignored all requests for comment, relying on his statement from last year, when the affair was revealed—his rep said he had only met Nuzzi once, for an interview that “[yielded a hit piece](#)”—to stand in for his side of the story. Kennedy's wife, *Curb Your Enthusiasm* actress Cheryl Hines, has stayed similarly mum. In [her own new book](#), which published a few weeks before Nuzzi's, she offers the barest explanation of dealing with “an ambiguous story about a political journalist” and subsequently making up with Kennedy.

So far, Kennedy's silence is serving him well. The reams of analysis that have been published on this affair have almost exclusively focused on Nuzzi: her breaches of journalistic ethics, her questionable taste in men, the [insufferable prose](#) of her book. She deserves the scrutiny. One of the “most famous political reporters in America,” as she [allegedly wrote](#) in a tabloid-style piece of fan fiction about herself, she threw away her credibility and career to have phone sex with a presidential candidate. She [promoted Kennedy](#) in interviews and [trashed his competition](#) in her reporting under the guise of objectivity, though she was allegedly acting as a secret [political operative](#) for the Kennedy campaign in between bouts of repulsive sexting. No one should trust her to ethically judge an eighth-grade essay contest, let alone write a political profile, ever again.

But the widespread lack of interest in Kennedy's role in the story has been glaring. This is one of the most powerful men in the country, the guy whose handpicked vaccine panel at the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention is currently undoing [decades of lifesaving progress](#) in public health. He allegedly spent a considerable amount of time having a virtual affair with a journalist during his campaign, then used her as a political resource as he plotted his ascent to the Cabinet. Even his denial, that he met Nuzzi only once, doesn't deny it. And no one really seems fazed. Not the media reporting on the affair, not any of the multitude of commentators who have offered their takes, and certainly not the Trump administration in which Kennedy serves. Some outlets have briefly hinted that Kennedy is not an innocent party here—the Bulwark, for one, nodded to the scandal “[implicating](#)” him—but there have been no major efforts to take him to task for his misdeeds.

This is in part because Kennedy is already regarded as a known cheater. In [a diary](#) he allegedly kept about his affairs during his second marriage (to Mary Richardson Kennedy, who later died by suicide), he recorded trysts with 37 women who weren't his wife in just one year. He is also a certified crackpot. Between his brain worm, his wackadoodle interactions with [animal carcasses](#), and his fetish for [conspiracy theories](#), a sexting affair seems positively commonplace. For journalists and the media-obsessed, the most avid consumers of content about the Nuzzi–Kennedy affair, Nuzzi's missteps are far more interesting than the timeworn tale of a powerful man behaving badly. And, anyway, famous men are generally [assigned less culpability](#) in extramarital affairs, as if infidelity were an immutable part of their nature.

But Kennedy's ability to evade the spotlight in this particular scandal also owes to his position in the Trump administration, which is led by a man who has seen few consequences from his own history of sexual misconduct. Donald Trump has emerged from decades of affairs and alleged sex crimes—including one for which a jury [found him liable](#)—to rapturous acclaim from around [40 percent of Americans](#) and the ever-moralizing evangelical community. He has near unanimous

support from the corners of the country that now believe [divorce](#) and [birth control](#) are intolerable symptoms of cultural decadence. The pillars of traditional sexual morality have shifted, such that their dictates no longer apply to anyone advancing the MAGA agenda.

Cheating Democrats have not enjoyed a similar loosening of norms. Consider the case of Cal Cunningham, the North Carolina candidate who ran as the Dems' best hope for taking control of the Senate in 2020. After it came out a few weeks before the election that Cunningham had been [having an affair](#) with a political consultant, he admitted that the [leaked texts](#) were real (what is with these men and their texts?!) and cut back on campaign events and interviews. His [favorability numbers sank](#), and his [polling lead diminished](#). In a joint editorial, two North Carolina newspapers [wrote](#) that they could no longer endorse Cunningham as planned, citing his "selfishness" and poor decision-making. He lost, taking the Biden agenda's hopes with him.

Kennedy has yet to be the subject of such scathing editorials about his fitness for office vis-à-vis his affairs, nor does the public seem to care (or, maybe, know) about the Nuzzi situation. In a poll of registered voters taken last week, right in the thick of Nuzzi's book coverage and two weeks after the [inaugural Lizza post](#), which has fetched more than [750,000 views](#), Kennedy was named one of the [most popular politicians](#) in the country.

There was a time when a vividly described affair corroborated by multiple parties, à la Kennedy's Harvestgate, would be a scandal for a U.S. official. Since the days of Democratic Sen. Gary Hart, who dropped out of the 1988 presidential race after the press [reported on his affair with a model](#), the extramarital goings-on of our leaders have been largely considered fair game for reporters. While some have argued that one's personal pursuits have no bearing on one's fitness for a political role, others believe that someone who makes a habit of hurting his loved ones (or harassing women, or having inappropriate workplace romances, or whatever sexual transgression you please) lacks good judgment, trustworthiness, and moral fortitude. That might not be a problem for a venture capital executive, but it's not the ideal profile for a public official in charge of, say, [measles](#).

But Americans have already come to expect the worst of men in Trump's orbit. The administration has made a point of hiring and retaining people who have been accused of [domestic violence](#), [sexual misconduct](#), and [general misogyny](#). As members of the broader American community and their own social circles, they are toxic jerks who make people's lives worse; as professionals in the government, they use those amoral instincts for a political purpose. Kennedy is one of countless officials Trump has tasked with running departments and agencies they are uniquely qualified to destroy. Any unseemly acts he or his colleagues commit merely function as further evidence of their aptitude for the job.

Granted, Nuzzi's indiscretions were a direct breach of her responsibilities as a journalist, while Kennedy's were not. There's no explicit expectation that married presidential candidates won't text reporters about felching. (That now seems a grave oversight.) But it remains an indictment of our current political reality that in the wake of the biggest sex scandal of the fiscal quarter, we're more fixated on the flailing journalist engineering her own downfall from Malibu than the guy deciding whether to [embargo our pills](#).

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